National Transportation Safety Board
Aviation Accident Final Report

Location:	Soledad, CA	**Accident Number:**	LAX08CA034
Date & Time:	12/06/2007, 1030 PST	**Registration:**	N6024M
Aircraft:	Air Tractor AT-401	**Aircraft Damage:**	Destroyed
Defining Event:		**Injuries:**	1 Serious
Flight Conducted Under:	Part 137: Agricultural		

Analysis

The pilot was seeding an area located adjacent to mountainous terrain. Prior to making the first pass, he had flown a reconnaissance flight to inspect the area. After completion of the first pass as he was maneuvering in a turn back towards the field, he was checking the seeding pattern and making adjustments to the GPS system inside the cockpit. When he checked the gauges again, he realized that the airplane had lost airspeed and rolled out to a wings level configuration to regain the lost airspeed. The airplane was headed towards rising terrain. He jettisoned the remaining seed and made a controlled collision with terrain in a ravine. The airplane was destroyed in a post impact fire. He reported that he had preoccupied himself with less important flight duties at a critical time during the flight. The pilot reported no mechanical problems that would have precluded normal operation.

Probable Cause and Findings

The National Transportation Safety Board determines the probable cause(s) of this accident to be: The pilot's failure to maintain an adequate clearance from mountainous terrain while maneuvering during an aerial application mission. Contributing to the accident was the pilot's diverted attention inside the cockpit.

Findings

Occurrence #1: IN FLIGHT COLLISION WITH TERRAIN/WATER
Phase of Operation: MANEUVERING - AERIAL APPLICATION

Findings
1. TERRAIN CONDITION - MOUNTAINOUS/HILLY
2. (C) IN-FLIGHT PLANNING/DECISION - INADEQUATE - PILOT IN COMMAND
3. (F) DIVERTED ATTENTION - PILOT IN COMMAND
4. (C) CLEARANCE - NOT MAINTAINED - PILOT IN COMMAND

Factual Information

Pilot Information

Certificate:	Commercial	**Age:**	40, Male
Airplane Rating(s):	Single-engine Land	**Seat Occupied:**	Center
Other Aircraft Rating(s):	Helicopter	**Restraint Used:**	Seatbelt, Shoulder harness
Instrument Rating(s):	None	**Second Pilot Present:**	No
Instructor Rating(s):	None	**Toxicology Performed:**	No
Medical Certification:	Class 2	**Last FAA Medical Exam:**	10/01/2007
Occupational Pilot:		**Last Flight Review or Equivalent:**	10/01/2007
Flight Time:	11000 hours (Total, all aircraft), 240 hours (Total, this make and model), 10740 hours (Pilot In Command, all aircraft), 300 hours (Last 90 days, all aircraft), 40 hours (Last 30 days, all aircraft)		

Aircraft and Owner/Operator Information

Aircraft Make:	Air Tractor	**Registration:**	N6024M
Model/Series:	AT-401	**Aircraft Category:**	Airplane
Year of Manufacture:		**Amateur Built:**	No
Airworthiness Certificate:	Restricted	**Serial Number:**	401-0949
Landing Gear Type:	Tailwheel	**Seats:**	1
Date/Type of Last Inspection:		**Certified Max Gross Wt.:**	9000 lbs
Time Since Last Inspection:		**Engines:**	1 Reciprocating
Airframe Total Time:		**Engine Manufacturer:**	Pratt & Whitney
ELT:		**Engine Model/Series:**	R1340
Registered Owner:	US Bancorp Equipment Finance Inc.	**Rated Power:**	600 hp
Operator:	SOILSERV INC	**Operating Certificate(s) Held:**	
Operator Does Business As:		**Operator Designator Code:**	LSHG

Meteorological Information and Flight Plan

Conditions at Accident Site:	Visual Conditions	**Condition of Light:**	Day
Observation Facility, Elevation:		**Distance from Accident Site:**	
Observation Time:		**Direction from Accident Site:**	
Lowest Cloud Condition:	Clear	**Visibility**	10 Miles
Lowest Ceiling:	None	**Visibility (RVR):**	
Wind Speed/Gusts:	Calm /	**Turbulence Type Forecast/Actual:**	/
Wind Direction:		**Turbulence Severity Forecast/Actual:**	/
Altimeter Setting:		**Temperature/Dew Point:**	10°C
Precipitation and Obscuration:	No Obscuration; No Precipitation		
Departure Point:	KING CITY, CA (KIC)	**Type of Flight Plan Filed:**	None
Destination:	(KIC)	**Type of Clearance:**	None
Departure Time:	1015 PST	**Type of Airspace:**	

Wreckage and Impact Information

Crew Injuries:	1 Serious	**Aircraft Damage:**	Destroyed
Passenger Injuries:	N/A	**Aircraft Fire:**	On-Ground
Ground Injuries:	N/A	**Aircraft Explosion:**	
Total Injuries:	1 Serious	**Latitude, Longitude:**	36.374167, -121.414167

Administrative Information

Investigator In Charge (IIC):	Tealeye C Cornejo	**Report Date:**	01/31/2008
Additional Participating Persons:	David Witt; Federal Aviation Administration; San Jose, CA		
Publish Date:			
Note:	This accident report documents the factual circumstances of this accident as described to the NTSB.		
Investigation Docket:	NTSB accident and incident dockets serve as permanent archival information for the NTSB's investigations. Dockets released prior to June 1, 2009 are publicly available from the NTSB's Record Management Division at pubinq@ntsb.gov, or at 800-877-6799. Dockets released after this date are available at http://dms.ntsb.gov/pubdms/.		

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The Independent Safety Board Act, as codified at 49 U.S.C. Section 1154(b), precludes the admission into evidence or use of any part of an NTSB report related to an incident or accident in a civil action for damages resulting from a matter mentioned in the report. A factual report that may be admissible under 49 U.S.C. § 1154(b) is available here.